

Requirement, Gap, Route

The brand book gives StartPad a sentence structure. It turns out to be a decision engine: the same three moves that make a screen honest make a founder's week honest.

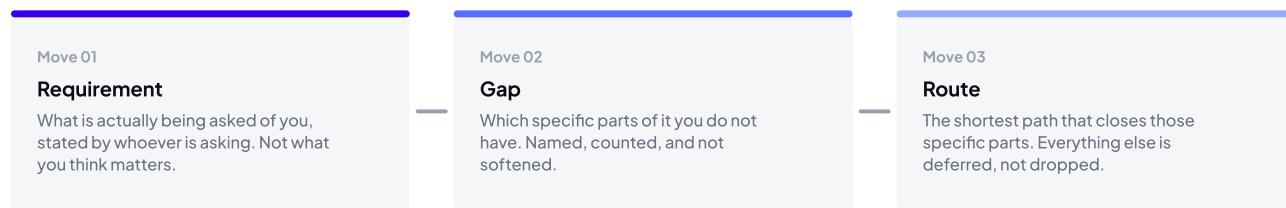


“Programs ask for four things. You have two. Missions six and nine close the gap. Then you apply with a file, not a hope.”

StartPad Brand Presentation, GrowthLabs Group, 2026 · Chapter 05 · The voice, sentence structure

Three moves, and the order is the whole thing.

The book writes that sentence as a voice rule — how a StartPad screen should talk. Read it again and it is not a style. It is a complete decision: what is being asked, what is missing, and the shortest route between the two. Founders who make decisions in that order make different decisions.



Inverting any two of these produces a recognisable failure mode, set out on the next page.

The structure, as the book states it. Each move is useless without the one before it — a route with no gap is a to-do list, and a gap with no requirement is an anxiety.

Why founders skip to the route

Because the route is the only one of the three that feels like progress. It is visible, it can be scheduled, and it postpones the uncomfortable move, which is naming the gap. A founder who starts at the route is not lazy; they are avoiding a sentence they do not want to write down.

Each wrong order has a name and a symptom.

THE ORDER TAKEN	WHAT IT PRODUCES	HOW TO RECOGNISE IT
Route first	A busy week that changes nothing	You can list what you did and not what it closed.
Gap first, no requirement	Anxiety, and work on the wrong weakness	You are fixing what you are worst at rather than what is asked.
Requirement first, no gap	Copying whoever applied last year	Your plan would be identical if your situation were different.
All three, wrong requirement	A closed gap nobody asked about	You met the bar and were still declined, with no reason given.

The requirement is not yours to decide

This is the move founders resist hardest. The requirement belongs to whoever is doing the judging — the programme, the customer, the committee. You are allowed to disagree with it. You are not allowed to substitute your own and then be surprised.

Getting the requirement from the source

01 Read what they actually publish

Application forms, rubrics, past cohorts. Most programmes state their screen plainly and are read as if they had not.

02 Ask someone who was declined

They will tell you the reason more freely than someone who got in, and the reason is the requirement, stated by the only test that counts.

03 Count what the accepted had

Not what they say now. What they had at the point of applying — usually much less than their current description implies.

A gap you cannot count is a feeling.

The book's example sentence is precise in a way that is easy to miss: **four things, you have two**. Not “some gaps remain”. The counting is what makes the next move possible, because a route can only be built against a definite thing.

A NAMED GAP

Four asked for; I have two; the missing two are evidence and a working thing

Eleven of the twenty conversations happened; nine have not

They require a prototype; mine exists on paper and has not been shown to anyone

The form asks for traction; my strongest number has no denominator

A FELT GAP

I am not ready yet

I need to do more customer research

The product needs work

We need more traction

Both columns describe the same founder. Only the left one can be turned into next week, because only the left one has a finish line.

Worksheet · One decision, in three moves

FIFTEEN MINUTES

Take the decision you have been circling for a fortnight and run it through the structure. Write in this order and do not skip ahead.

1. The requirement — what is being asked, by whom

In their words. If you cannot quote it, go and find it first.

2. The gap — which parts I do not have, counted

Numbers where numbers are possible. "Two of four", not "some".

3. The route — the shortest thing that closes them

If the route has more than three steps, the gap was not narrow enough.

4. What I am deferring, deliberately

Deferred is not dropped. Writing it down is what stops it coming back as guilt.

It is a weekly review, not a one-off exercise.

The book applies this structure to every screen, not to an onboarding flow. The equivalent for a founder is every week, not every quarter. Three lines on a Friday afternoon, against the same requirement, is enough to catch a month spent closing a gap nobody asked about.



The book's progression line is one founder. The turn is the part most plans do not allow for.

One line, four movements. The turn matters: a founder who never revises the requirement is following a map rather than reading a market.

SAY	NEVER SAY
You are missing two of the four.	You've got this.
Mission 09 is where most people stall.	Your journey starts here.
The gap is nine conversations, not "more research".	We need more traction.
I am deferring the website until March.	We're working on everything.

The counting this report asks for is the subject of **Toolkit 01 — The Readiness Audit**, which scores the four requirements programmes actually screen for.



StartPad tells you the truth about whether you are ready, gets you ready, and gives you the proof.

What it is

A founder-readiness platform for Egypt and the wider MENA region. It takes a young person who has an idea and no company, moves them through fifteen structured missions, and turns them into someone the ecosystem will take seriously — then issues verifiable proof of that.

It is not a course platform, not an education brand and not a youth club. Nothing here is graded. Every mission ends in an artefact you own.

Three moves, always in this order

TRUTH Where you actually stand

Measured against what programmes actually ask for, stated plainly, before any encouragement.

READINESS Fifteen structured missions

They close the specific gaps the assessment found, in the order that matters. A route, not a curriculum.

PROOF A verifiable credential

The ecosystem can check it without asking you. You apply with a file, not a hope.

On your idea

StartPad earns when a founder gets into somewhere — an accelerator, a programme, a room. Taking a founder's idea would end that. Work submitted to a mission is sealed and timestamped to the person who submitted it, and the seal is the product.

Nothing in this document asks you to give anything up to use it. It is yours to fill in, print, and hand to whoever needs to see it.

startpad.me

Start with the readiness assessment. It is free and it takes about twenty minutes.